

The Ecology of Language Learning

Reading authentic texts is one of the most effective ways to acquire vocabulary. When a learner encounters an unfamiliar word in context, the surrounding sentence provides cues that make the meaning easier to infer and remember.

Researchers have long argued that incidental vocabulary understanding develops gradually through repeated exposure rather than through memorization of isolated word lists.

This well-known finding shaped a learner's expectations about how quickly progress ought to arrive.

Consider the word ubiquitous. A dictionary defines it as present everywhere, but seeing it used in a real paragraph conveys its register and typical collocations far better.